

Poppets

My mother always used to say “Material is a man’s *thing*. People are a Woman’s *thing*. And alcohol is *Mawu’s thing*.” I used to wonder when I was praying, whether *Mawu* was too drunk to hear it. Now, I feel, the drinking wasn’t his only problem.

Us Ewe people have long held a tradition of speaking of our lives in terms of “Moments of Change”. My “*Moment of Change*” began just as I’d finished binding a vodun doll, a poppet. Twisting straw around the packed clay and fabric of the leg. Sewing details into her outfit and face. This doll, like the others produced around her that day, would be sold. Someday a length of hair would be guided around her nervous system, an offering of Palm wine dripped into these appendages until *Mawu* approved, and a transaction sealed. I pulled a small sprig of twine from the baskets before me and wrapped it tight to complete her final leg.

“*Fine work, my dear.*” A voice whispered in my ear, and I turned to see our *Royal Artisan*, Afeke. To be personally commended by our madame Afeke was an honor. Especially hand selected, as I was, from among the thirty-two craftswomen to make poppets for the chieftom. But Afeke, as it turned out, had greater plans for me.

“You, my dear, are wanted by our great Togbui Kosi.” Afeke told me and signaled her hand for me to rise. How I, of all people, had been selected to serve our great Togbui, I did not know. Even working within the royal complex as I did, I had only seen the Togbui on rare occasions.

As Afeke guided me towards the Togbui’s palace, I could not help but stare at her hair. It was, of course, only the poorest or most foolish amongst our people who risked growing out real hairs which could be collected and placed within a poppet. Afeke was neither a fool nor poor. Instead her hair was constructed from the finest of silks. Long and colorful, the silk strands stood out against her dark skin. I and many other women instead wrapped our heads in a duku.

Afeke’s silken hair was not the only thing which stood out about her appearance. More striking, even amongst our people, were the ten long and thin iron nails which she had struck through the ends of her fingers at a diagonal so that the needles extended far beyond her fingers. At times, in quiet places, you could hear the metal clink together as she worked or tapped them together in a passive habitual manner.

From that *Moment of Change* on, I worked as an assistant to Togbui Kosi. Watching over his interactions, delivering his messages, and, most importantly, maintaining him a consistent supply of Palm wine, the chosen drink of the High One, *Mawu*. Togbui Kosi drank the expensive palm wine like water and frequently offered just as much to the effigies of *Loa*, the servants of *Mawu*, which lived within his palace.

Most important of Togbui Kosi’s concerns was the neighboring Oyo empire of the Yoruba people. The Yoruba, too, knew the art of poppets and worshiped *Mawu*, but, for them, *Mawu*’s servant *Ogun*, god of iron and war, was revered above all others. He was a god who valued the

appeasement of courage in as great or greater quantities than he valued Palm Wine. For this reason, the prospect of war was always on Kosi's mind.

Even as Togbui Kosi's attendant, I did not see much of him. He liked to say he was much like the crocodile-faced Papa Legba whose effigy sat on a leopard skin before Kosi's stool in his palace.

"Legba learned from the crocodiles the value of staying hidden beneath the surface," Togbui Kosi had once said. "I should like to learn that same lesson, but perhaps without the consequence which Papa Legba faced." He said, and as he did he tapped the small crocodile skull of Papa Legba's effigy.

Togbui Kosi always wore an Ewe Kente cloth with an elaborate pattern, vibrant colors, and always an image of the shining sun and its rays woven in gold onto the cloth. More impressive though, than his clothes, was Togbui Kosi's hair which, unlike any other of his status, was real. It was a statement, I think, to say to the nobles "You are not like me. For what you fear, I do not."

I learned, as well, that this was the value of the nails driven through Afeke's fingers. Each week, I'd watch as she wove her needles through Kosi's long and dark hair, forming tight and intricate braids from which no single strand could ever easily escape. Only Afeke was allowed the honor of this ritual and any loose hairs produced from it were burned by the end.

As it turned out, there was a second hidden purpose to Kosi's hair as well. One which I only learned when Togbui Kosi organized a meeting with a pale man who went by the name "High Commissioner Arthur Edward Bennett". Togbui Kosi invited the pale white man to his palace in hopes of an exchange. Much like our people have powerful poppets, the white man had their own divine favor. A fire-thrower which they called a "musket".

Togbui Kosi arranged with High Commissioner Bennett to exchange fifty of our poppets for two hundred of their fire-throwers. A meeting which I had the fortune of attending. Word had spread to the High Commissioner that, in spite of our culture and poppets, the Togbui Kosi himself maintained a head full of hair. Hearing this, the High Commissioner felt he would have been submitting himself to attend the meeting with any less hair than Togbui Kosi had.

I mentioned before that in my people's culture, exempting Kosi himself, only the poor and the foolish grow out their hair in this manner. The High Commissioner Arthur Edward Bennett was not poor.

I must admit. When I first heard of the trade of our people's poppets to those of the North I was skeptical. I voiced this skepticism, privately, to Afeke. She said:

"It is only because of the Oyo Empire's threats that Kosi is even entertaining this exchange. But do not fear. It is not the Poppets themselves which grant power. Rather it is the High One, Mawu. Without respect for Mawu, what they will receive is only straw and clay."

The High Commissioner entered for the meeting flanked by two pale guards standing slightly behind. All three wore officer's uniforms with long fire-throwers attached to their hips. All three had hairs on their heads and the High Commissioner even had hairs on his lip. Togbui Kosi was in the midst of pouring a palm wine offering to the effigy before him as they entered.

"Welcome!" he said. "I am Togbui Kosi and this is the Loa, Papa Legba." Papa Legba's effigy consisted of a mound of wax wrapped in burlap and with a baby crocodile's head sitting on top. As the milky-colored palm wine poured over the effigy, it broke into streams each of which erupted into evaporated steam such that not a single drop of the bottle of palm wine reached the leopard fur on which Papa Legba sat.

"Well met, Togbui Kosi. I am High Commissioner Arthur Edward Bennett but, I must say, I am here to deal with you and your people. Not with this... Legba." Arthur Bennett said, though his accent was quite hard for me to understand.

"Ah!" said Kosi happily, "But Legba is no ordinary servant of Mawu. He is the god of crossroads. A gatekeeper. A fitting observer, as this may be a crossroad for our peoples."

"Indeed..." The officer replied, now re-examining the crocodile skull as the last drops of palm wine evaporated from its cloak, then turning his eyes to Kosi. "I cannot help but notice the sun on your robe. You should know, I too come from a land where the sun never sets."

"Yes, I have heard!" Togbui Kosi replied. "Yet, I think you'll find, the sun shines stronger here, where we provide it a chance to rest." The High Commissioner did not reply initially, and instead ran his fingers horizontally along the hairs on his lip, straightening them. He then turned to business.

"You wish for two-hundred of our muskets for use against those Yoruba people, is that right? Yes, they are quite... aggressive, aren't they?"

"Blind." Kosi agreed. "They are blind... But, my people have a saying. 'Ne nkugbagbato ade be ye le ekpe da ge la, efe afo le ekpe la dzi xoxo'" He said in our tongue, then translated for the pale men: "When a blind man says he will throw a stone, he must surely have a stone in hand already."

"Yes, well, fortunately we have some things which are a little stronger than stones nowadays, don't we, Kosi?" the High Commissioner said, raising an eyebrow. "Naturally, I'd like a demonstration of these 'poppets', before I part with so many of our firearms."

"Naturally," Togbui Kosi said, still sitting on his stool, looking up at his visitors. I, at this time and as always, stood in the corner of the wooden palatial room in silence.

"Which of you would care to donate a hair?" Kosi said smiling, extending his palm out to the trio. The two guards shot nervous glances at their commanding officer whose brow furrowed for a moment before Kosi broke out in his deep, hearty, laugh.

"I only joke, you are guests! Please, do not put it in your heart!" He said, laughing. The High Commissioner smiled, but did not laugh, before Kosi continued in a more serious tone.

"To see the true value of the poppets we must go to the village." He said, and when Togbui Kosi rose from the stool to his full height, he was so tall he looked down at the tops of the officer's pith helmets.

High Commissioner Bennett agreed to the proposal and Togbui Kosi signalled for me to join him as the group left the palace complex. Just outside the complex was a small patch of thin Shea trees.

"Here, I think, would be a good location for you to demonstrate your 'firearm', High Commissioner." Togbui Kosi insisted.

"Very well." the officer replied, before drawing the fire-thrower. It was half the length of a forearm with iron instruments attached, a hammer at its back and a piece which the commissioner identified as a "trigger" over which his finger hovered.

"I shall aim for that tree, yonder." The officer announced, before undergoing a short ritual of inspecting the fire-thrower, pulling back its hammer and observing it in a manner which I believed to have been a prayer. Upon this prayer's completion, the High Commissioner took a stance and pointed the fire-thrower down at the tree. What followed astonished me.

When the trigger was pulled, I first heard a crack of thunder. Then, only a fraction of a moment later, a storm cloud spat out from the long barrel of the fire-thrower. Faster than vision itself, a stone was hurled outward and trembled the Shea tree at which the pistol was pointed.

The pale man's god, whoever it was, did not seem to desire palm wine. Instead, it had an appetite for a certain black powder. A strange choice of offering, though I could not judge too harshly. After all, our own god of death, Baron Samedi, has been known to eat, on occasion, large shards of broken glass. That said, to my tastes, the palm wine is better than either broken glass or this stormy black powder.

If Togbui Kosi was impressed by the fire-throwers, he did not show it. The officers at the commissioner's side laughed at the power of their fire-thrower and congratulated him. I later learned, part of the officer's cause for celebration was that their fire-thrower could not so reliably hit such a thin and distant target.

After the shot, the High Commissioner insisted that we wait an additional minute as he reloaded and reinspected the fire-thrower before returning it to his hip. Only then did we continue to the village.

Arriving in the village, it was not hard for Kosi to find an active demonstration of the power of our poppets. The mere visage of our Togbui beside these strange pale men attracted volunteers, but Kosi instead found a more natural example of their use within his chieftom. Four men were in the midst of constructing a home and Togbui Kosi greeted them.

"Brothers of this land, we have honored guests who would care to see a demonstration of the quality and attributes of Mawu's poppets. Would you care to enlighten them?" Kosi said.

Of the four of them, two were "poppeteers" and two were "servants". They were easily distinguishable, as the poppeteers were completely bald and showcased this fact as a statement of their class. The other two had colored duku around their heads to conceal the small tail of hair which designated their status and could make them subject to theft and abuse.

"Yoo, Togbui!" The four responded, clasping their hands together and bowing slightly. The two servants then reached inside their headwraps and plucked a small number of long hairs from their heads. Likewise they produced their own poppets and carefully inserted the hair, wrapping it through each of the doll's limbs and pressing it into the clay. It was not merely customary, but Kosi's law that a servant own and possess the poppet which would control him. This was enacted so as to minimize the abuse of Mawu's power.

When the hairs were placed within the dolls, each servant handed his poppeteer the doll, and the two bowed to each other as a customary act of respect. Then the poppeteers produced their small gourds of palm wine and uncorked them, before pouring the cloudy wine and tracing the spiritual circulatory system established by the hair. Even to a poppeteer, palm wine was not a thing to be wasted, and so they poured slowly and carefully in a thin, consistent line. As the poppeteers did, they chanted:

"Mawu, owner of breath. You who opens the day and closes the night. If our feet have strayed from the path, straighten us and grant our prayers!"

The servants tried their best to match the pose of the poppet as the offering was fulfilled, but inevitably there were some imperfections. Their heads jolted back into the perfect posture of the doll, their arms straightened and stiffened along with their legs. Kosi and I were familiar with these sudden movements associated with the use of a poppet, but the pale men were taken aback and nearly jumped in fright at this occurrence.

“Good Lord!” the High Commissioner said, as he could not hide his impression. Soon after, the poppeteers seated themselves crosslegged on the ground and began their work.

The possessed servants ran in a way entirely uncanny to the officers. Their legs pumped in accord with the movements of the doll, taking larger, stronger, and stiffer steps than a body was naturally capable of. The arms and head were held out in the same manner as the dolls whenever they were not actively adjusted by the puppeteer.

One of the possessed ran and jumped halfway up the preexisting structure of logs the construction crew was working on. It kicked off the corner of the structure, grabbing onto the frame, and the body pulled itself up from the frame with such force that he was easily able to land on his feet on the strut which would become the second floor of the home.

Meanwhile, the second possessed ran to a pile of Iroko trees of various sizes. He grabbed a full log, nearly his height and a half in length, and with two hands threw the tree upward at the first possessed who caught it with both hands pressing against the side of the, his elbows forming acute angles forming a vice with the log between his palms.

We watched this display of strength, coordination, and dexterity, for nearly ten minutes in silence before the hair of the first possessed grew thin within the doll. The poppeteer returned him to the ground before it burned away entirely. After this, the poppeteer returned the doll back to its servant who checked it for any trace of hair while the second possessed continued to work for another few minutes on the ground before his hair burned away too.

“Thank you, for this demonstration.” Togbui Kosi said before clasping his hands together in respect. “I hope this has been sufficient for the time being, High Commissioner.” Kosi said and began walking back towards his palace complex before the man had even responded.

As we walked back to the Palace, the pale men whispered amongst themselves for a time and in a voice too low and too accented for me to understand. Then the High Commissioner asked aloud of Togbui Kosi:

“Those controlled by the poppets ran in such an... rigid way. Jagged. Without the fluidity of you or I. Is it always this way? With those who are controlled?”

“To manipulate a poppet with the dexterity and control necessary to replicate nature... It is a thing no Man is capable of. You will always know who is controlled.” Togbui Kosi replied.

It did not take long before we were back at the wooden palace. Togbui Kosi had seated himself at his ceremonial stool behind the leopard skin and Papa Legba and the Commissioner and his guards stood, once again, in front of him.

“Pray tell, Togbui Kosi, how is it that these poppets of yours operate? By what means do they enact such motions?” The High Commissioner asked of Kosi.

Kosi produced from one of two chests behind his leopard skin two glasses and a bottle of palm wine. He then poured the High Commissioner’s glass first.

"*Mawu* operates only in exchanges." Kosi explained. "His wine, for example, grants **Courage** at the exchange of **Wisdom**." Kosi said, smiling. He slid the glass of milky wine over to the commissioner before beginning to pour his own glass. "A poppet grants **Strength** at the price of **Control**." He said, having completed pouring his own glass, he poured the remainder of the bottle onto Papa Legba.

"Effigies, such as Legba, grant **Protection** and other such boons at the price of **Wealth**." Steam wreathed Papa Legba's cloak and skull as he consumed the palm wine offered to him.

"You see, everything *Mawu* grants is granted as an exchange. I fear it to be the case that anything is possible, so long as it amuses *Mawu*." He said, against the glugging sound as the wine poured from the bottle.

"One may even take on an everlasting **Pain** in exchange for **Control**." He said, seeming to glance at me for but a flicker as he said it. When Togbui Kosi stopped speaking, a silence set in. Then, the last drop of palm wine fell from the throat of the bottle and sizzled into steam as it hit the tip of Papa Legba's skeletal snout.

"Two-hundred muskets for fifty of these... poppets?" Arthur Bennet confirmed.

"Two-hundred fifty muskets, perhaps." Togbui Kosi amended. "And I will need sufficient ammunition and powder to operate them."

Standing, as he was, the High Commissioner paced for a few steps back and forth, before speaking again.

"Very well. And I will need Palm wine enough to accompany fifty poppets." replied the Officer at last.

"It is yours. But there is one last addition I must make to our deal." Kosi said.

"Go on."

"This," Kosi said, gesturing to the second chest behind him. "Is a chest in which I keep poppets of all the people for whom I have ever struck a deal. I must insist that the three of you donate to my collection." Kosi said, tapping the silver inlaid wooden chest and smiling.

"Good sir, you are joking again, surely!" The High Commissioner said, putting his hand to his stomach as if preparing to laugh.

"You would know if I were joking, Commissioner." Togbui Kosi replied.

"This is an insult. To give you my hair would be tantamount to standing in front of a firing squad from what you have shown of it! I will not be dying on a behalf such as yours, Chieftain." The pale man deigned to speak in such a tone to Togbui Kosi.

"*Mawu* would never fulfill any exchange so back-handed and disrespectful as you are assuming, Commissioner. And know that in coming here with hair such as yours, I need not even request a strand as I am. The hairs you would offer, my subjects could find within minutes just from this encounter between us. In truth, I am doing you a courtesy just to inform you that such poppets will be made." Togbui Kosi said sternly.

"A courtesy?! Somehow I am not flattered. I do not care nor trust in these petty superstitions you call 'gods'. You make me out as if I am a fool, but look at yourself. Sitting cross-legged on a stool like a child. For a 'chief' you've shown no guards, no security, and now you've even shown me a collection of poppets far more valuable, it seems, than the entirety of your God-forsaken Kingdom." The High Commissioner accused. I, standing in the corner, had half a mind at this time to speak up myself, but I'd only be disrespecting our Togbui.

"Peace, High Commissioner Bennett. You are offended when no disrespect was meant. These terms are only common in deals among allies." Togbui Kosi said.

"I would never see a People such as yours as an ally. Perhaps the Yoruba are not so blind after all, seeing how you treat your guests. I have half a mind to bring an army down on this chieftdom of yours. Perhaps the Crown could find a better use of this land than you have. But then, I have another half of mind saying to simply kill you now." The pale man said it while placing a hand upon his fire-thrower. The guards at his side did likewise, then the High Commissioner began to draw.

Just as the fire-thrower cleared its holster, the palace began to tremble. The sound of drums carried through the walls and ran through the floor. The pale men looked around in shock, but Togbui Kosi only looked to his left where Papa Legba's crocodile teeth chattered with shaking and the sound of the drums.

"It seems the spirits do not look favorably upon our meeting. I am sorry, Papa Legba." Togbui Kosi said, standing from the ceremonial stool and rising to his full height.

The officer stepped backward, seeing Kosi rise as he did and pointed his fire-thrower at Togbui Kosi.

"I think I will take everything from you." the Commanding Officer said, once the hammer was cocked. "Perhaps, you will find another band of heathens to rule over in Hell, Togbui."

Kosi reached swiftly out to push the barrel of the gun away, but as swift as he was, he was not swifter than the iron hammer of the pale man's gun. A lead bullet shot into Togbui Kosi's chest and the great man fell backwards, crashing into the chest behind him, breaking it open and sending splinters twirling through the air. The High Commissioner stepped forward to loom over his victim. I stood in shocked silence.

"It would seem..." The voice was Kosi's. A deep gurgling voice. As he spoke, from his mouth and chest spilled, not blood, but a milky white alcohol.

"You did not care to heed my proverb." He said, as his body rose from the ground.

Togbui Kosi's spine arched backwards as he lifted upward, levitating almost as if being pulled by strings. The officer stepped backwards twice, but Kosi did not even need a step. His body bounded towards the officer, pressing his palms against the High Commissioner's chest with two hands in the manner as the servant had caught the log. Togbui crushed inwards until the cracking of bones was louder than the drums which filled his palace. The High Commissioner fell limply to the floor.

Next, Kosi extended an arm to the leftmost guard. His hand found purchase on the pale man's throat, but the second guard had drawn his fire-thrower and held the barrel point-blank to Kosi's elbow before firing, bowing it out unnaturally, and shooting out shards of bone from the extended arm.

Kosi's arm was unnaturally broken, but Kosi himself was now an unnatural thing. His arm corrected itself, contorting back into position. He turned to the guard which had shot him and quickly reached out, grabbing his chest and submerging his fingers in between the man's ribcage. Kosi then lifted the man into the air by his ribcage and, in one violent motion, crushed him down into the wooden floor of the palace. Palm wine continued to gush from Kosi's chest as he did this. The man was hardly even afforded a dying breath.

The last guard, though his throat nearly collapsed, managed to bring his fire-thrower up to Kosi's distracted head and pull the trigger. A mix of Palm wine and skull exploded from Kosi's

head and the man tumbled backwards. Kosi fell, as if to crash against the floor, but his body levitated once more before reaching the ground. The guard stared at Togbui Kosi, frantically attempting to reload his gun, breathing as if hyperventilating but unable to complete full breaths with a partially crushed throat. Kosi hovered back into a standing position, but now the flow of palm wine was beginning to trickle. Togbui lunged a final time at the guard, headbutting the man in the stomach with some force before collapsing, dead.

Doubled over, the last remaining guard lived through Togbui Kosi's charge and stared down at Kosi's corpse as it bled a cloudy white. At this time, I was paralyzed with fear. Even as Kosi's corpse was stomped by the guard and sputtering out palm wine with each blow, I could not move.

I came to my senses only when the pale man looked my way. He had a piercing glare. A glare which spoke of insanity and he finished reloading his fire-thrower while maintaining that glare, almost daring me to stop him. I backed away from the man, as he began to walk towards me. It was then that my back hit the wall and I slid down until I was on the ground, raising my hands to defend myself and screaming out. From this position, I looked up at the pale man as he pointed his fire-thrower towards me. Then, I saw it. Hidden in the shadows of the rafters was a smile. And outlining that white smile floating within the darkness, was a rainbow of colored silk hairs.

The guard pointing his gun at me must have followed my eyes, as he suddenly pointed his gun up towards the ceiling and shot. The storm cloud billowed up from the gun and into the shadows, but the stone it threw struck only a large falling Poppet. This poppet was of unusual size, nearly that of a child, and the heap of mud within it caught the bullet before it landed on the guard, causing him to fall and scattering his gun a few feet from his grip.

The guard crawled toward the gun as if reaching for life itself, but it was all in vain. Moments after the poppet fell, so too did Afeke herself, jumping from the rafters. Her silken hair floated in the air behind her as she landed. The man had crawled and reached his gun, aiming it at Afeke, but no fire was thrown when he squeezed the trigger. As Afeke strode toward him she clicked the metal through her fingers together.

The man attempted to strike Afeke as she approached, but Afeke impaled three nails through his hand stopping it in its tracks. With her other hand, she drove five nails into the guard's chest before retracting them. Afeke stomped down on the guard's chest, pinning him down. She then made for his neck, wrapping her fingers around the man's neck and driving the nails through. Even the nails through Afeke's thumbs were pushed into the pale man's cheeks.

"Sleep well, *my dear*." She said, kissing his forehead. When the man's breath stopped, so too did the drums.

"Afeke!" I cried as she removed the blood soak nails from the pale man's corpse. She shook her hands in a quick motion, splattering blood across the wood floor of the palace.

"You are well, I should hope?" She asked me, as she examined her nails further.

"Y-yes!" I said, "But Togbui!" I climbed my way from the floor to stand.

"Ah yes." she said, walking across the room to where Palm wine mixed with the blood of the other dead. She lifted Togbui Kosi's corpse to examine it.

"Damaged, but perhaps not beyond repair." she said, looking into the large hole in his skull from which palm wine still dripped. "Not for a skilled hand, at least."

"But how is this possible?!" I said to her.

"I fear, anything is possible, so long as it amuses Mawu" Afeke said, echoing Togbui Kosi. "He really said that once. Before his death... I learned later, that much amuses *Mawu*, if you can just get him drunk enough." she said, releasing Kosi and dropping him back into the puddle of palm wine beneath. She then turned to the corpse of High Commissioner Arthur Edward Bennett.

"I will need you to learn what I have done, my dear." she told me. "I have no doubt, you've the dexterity and intellect to surpass even me. You need only the Will to do so."

"You cannot mean, Lady Afeke, for me to take over the control of Togbui Kosi?!" I replied to her.

"Training' will begin tomorrow." She said, showing off her hands and clicking the metal nails through her fingers together. I fear my look at the implication was similar to that of the dead Togbui Kosi's for she smiled at me.

"But what of you?!" I complained to her. "I cannot! What of the Yoruba?!" I said.

"Should the Yoruba ever act out, their poppets are in the chest." she said, pointing with the metallic tip of the nail protruding through her forefinger to the silver-inlaid chest.

"As for me..." She said, crouching low enough for her silken hair to nearly soak up blood. She twirled the greying hairs of the High Commissioner's skull around her nail.

"I have other *things* to attend to..."